BRINGING BACK THE BUSTARD

The Great Indian Bustard, once a contender for national bird status, is now critically endangered. Can the captive breeding programme in Rajasthan reverse the tide?

BY ROHIT PARIHAR

Two temperature-regulated shelter homes in Rajasthan, some 170 km apart—one near the famous dunes of Sam and the other next to Pokhran—house 23 chicks of the Great Indian Bustard (GIB). They have never seen the outside world and will never be released. Scientists have hatched them from eggs in captivity and will wait for them to breed. The chicks of the 'founder population', as they are called, will then be released into the wild. For the woefully endangered GIB, it's a matter of life and death, and a lot hinges on the success of this project.

The GIB, which decades ago had been in the running to be India's national bird, today seems to be fighting a losing battle. Listed as critically endangered by the International Union for Conservation of Nature and accorded the highest protection under India's Wild Life (Protection) Act, it has lost over 90 per cent of its natural range. Only about 150 GIBs are left globally, and all are in India. Of them, most are in and around the Desert National Park near Jaisalmer, the only breeding habitat, with Gujarat, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Maharashtra now accounting for less than 10 birds each. So far, efforts at conservation have been a sombre journey, punctuated by optimism and perseverance but also roadblocks and disappointment. The captive breeding project may be a silver lining against this experience, but it's not without challenges.

Launched in 2019, the project is at a critical stage. Two chicks have died within a month, taking the number of deaths to six since the programme began. Scientists are also struggling to take care of the nine youngest birds from the previous breeding season that were recently shifted, one by one, from the makeshift centre in Sam to a permanent facility in Ramdeora, Pokhran, and 14 subadults that are expected to lay eggs in around two years. Nonetheless, scientists remain optimistic. "The mortality [of the young chicks] is within the level experienced at conservation breeding centres for other bustard species across the world," says Sutirtha Dutta, a scientist at the Wildlife Institute of India (WII), Dehradun, who has been supervising the captive breeding programme.

A joint effort of the Rajasthan government, the WII, the Centre and the International Fund for Houbara Conservation (IFHC), Abu Dhabi (which has successfully bred and released the Houbara, a species similar to the GIB, into the wild), the project aims to have a 'founder population' of 30 birds. "The population maintained in captivity is an insurance against extinction and their chicks will be subsequently released back into the wild after threats to their survival are mitigated," says Arindam Tomar, the chief wildlife warden of Rajasthan. So far, 31 eggs have been collected from the wild, of which 29 were incubated and hatched artificially. Only 23 birds hatched in this experiment have survived so far. Of concern is the fact that the populations outside Rajasthan are likely to become extinct soon as they are not viable and the eggs being laid in Andhra Pradesh are non-fertile.

Collecting eggs is no walk in the park. The GIB lays only one egg in a year of good monsoon, or two in rare cases. Experts track the female and wait for it to breed before taking away the eggs. Timely removal often induces a female to lay another one. So, trackers in Jaisalmer have been collecting about half the eggs they spot, without risk-